battle. The army commander disclaims that responsibility.'

Thapar finally reacted. He seemed to shake himself out of a reverie. "A-ho," he replied in Punjabi, and looked at Palit inquiringly. The DMO's first suggestion was that they should recall the BGS to the Ops Room.

Having brought the chief's attention back to the prevailing situation, Palit suggested that Brigadier Gurbax Singh's 48 Brigade in Bomdila be immediately de-linked from 4 Division's command and henceforth be controlled by IV Corps. 'Pathania at Senge must not be made to look back over his shoulder. All his attention must be riveted on the Se-la battle.' Thapar nodded his assent, but the BGS had just realized that his corps commander had not bothered to inform either Eastern Command or Army HQ that he had authorized Pathania to set up 4 Division's HQ at Dirang Dzong more than a fortnight ago. It was incredible—what the entire Chinese Army knew was not known to the Indian high command. It also meant none of the officers in the chain of command was aware of the fact that 65 Brigade was also not on Se-la but had been deployed to defend Dirang Dzong instead. In fact, there were three points that needed to be defended, not two!

Not only was Anant Pathania seventy kilometres from the battle unfolding at Se-la, his position at Dirang Dzong had not yet been fortified. Now that he had realized that the comfortable quarters built by the Border Roads Organisation was not secure, that was all he could focus on. 4 Division HQ had already ordered 13 Dogra to detach two of its companies at Senge Dzong and rush them to Dirang.

Just then, the telephone in the Ops Room rang and Pathania came through on the line. Speaking to K. K. Singh, the GOC said that there were reports of Chinese troops having come around the left flank of Se-la. The road between Se-la and Dirang Dzong could be severed any minute, while the Dirang Dzong-Bomdila road had already been cut off. Pathania added that the line of communication between him and Bomdila already seemed to have been cut, for he was unable to raise Gurbax Singh. Pathania once again asked for permission to withdraw 4 Infantry Division. Just where the GOC wanted to pull back to remained a mystery.

Keeping Pathania on hold, K. K. Singh told Thapar, Sen and Palit what Pathania had said. Neither the chief nor the army commander said anything. Palit told the BGS to firmly tell Pathania there was no question of a withdrawal.